

APPLIED ENGLISH

Unit-I: Comprehension

Comprehensive Study Notes

As per HPU BCA Semester-I Syllabus

1. Comprehension

1.1 What is Comprehension?

Comprehension is the ability to understand and interpret written text. In HPU BCA exams, you get ONE unseen passage of 250–300 words, followed by questions that test your understanding, vocabulary, and analytical skills.

Importance of Comprehension

- Develops reading and analytical skills
- Enhances vocabulary through context
- Improves critical thinking and interpretation
- Carries significant weightage in HPU BCA exams

1.2 Types of Passages

S.No.	Type	Description	Examples
1	Factual Passage	Based on facts, data, instructions, or reports	Instructions, descriptions, reports
2	Literary Passage	Extracts from fiction, drama, poetry, essays, or biographies	Fiction, drama, poetry, essay, biography
3	Discursive Passage	Opinion-based texts that are argumentative or persuasive	Argumentative, persuasive texts

1.3 How to Attempt Comprehension Questions

Step	Action	Time
1	Read the passage quickly to get the general idea	2 minutes

2	Read all questions carefully	1 minute
3	Read the passage again, underlining keywords	3 minutes
4	Answer in your own words — do NOT copy directly from the passage	5 minutes
5	Use complete sentences	2 minutes
6	Check spelling and grammar	2 minutes

Total time management: Maximum 15 minutes for this section.

2. Word-Attack Skills (5 Marks)

2.1 Word Formation: Prefixes and Suffixes

Prefixes

Prefixes are added at the beginning of a word to change its meaning.

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
un-	Not	unhappy, unfair, unkind
re-	Again	rewrite, replay, rebuild
pre-	Before	preview, preheat, prewritten
mis-	Wrongly	misunderstand, mislead, misplace
dis-	Not / Reverse	disappear, dislike, displease
in-/il-/im-/ir-	Not	invisible, illegal, immature, irrational
over-	Too much	overeat, overwork, oversleep
under-	Too little	undercook, underpaid, underestimate
inter-	Between	international, interact, interstate
sub-	Under	submarine, subordinate, subnormal
super-	Above	superman, superstar, supernatural
anti-	Against	antibiotic, antifreeze, antisocial
auto-	Self	automatic, automobile, autobiography
bi-	Two	bicycle, bilingual, biweekly
tri-	Three	triangle, tricycle, triple

multi-	Many	multicolor, multinational, multimedia
post-	After	postpone, postscript, postgraduate
trans-	Across	transport, translate, transform

Suffixes

Suffixes are added at the end of a word to change its meaning or grammatical function.

Suffix	Meaning	Examples
-ness	State of	happiness, kindness, sadness
-tion / -sion	Action / Process	education, information, conclusion
-ly	In a manner	slowly, quickly, happily
-able / -ible	Capable of	comfortable, lovable, flexible
-ful	Full of	beautiful, careful, helpful
-less	Without	hopeless, helpless, careless
-ment	Action / Result	movement, enjoyment, development
-er / -or	One who does	teacher, actor, investigator
-ize / -ise	To make	summarize, activate, organize
-en	To make	strengthen, darken, soften
-hood	State / condition	childhood, adulthood, brotherhood
-ship	State / skill	friendship, leadership, scholarship
-ist	One who practices	artist, scientist, biologist
-ism	Belief / practice	capitalism, socialism, criticism
-dom	State / domain	freedom, kingdom, wisdom

2.2 Inferring Meaning from Context

When you encounter an unknown word, use the surrounding text to guess its meaning.

Techniques

- Look for clues in the same sentence
- Look for synonyms or explanations provided nearby
- Look for contrast words (but, however, although, yet)
- Read the sentences before and after the unknown word

Example

"The children were ravenous after playing all day; they ate their food quickly."

Here, *ravenous* means **extremely hungry** because the context suggests they ate quickly after playing.

3. 50+ Important Synonyms

Synonym: A word that has the same or nearly the same meaning as another word.

#	Word	Synonyms
1	Abandon	Leave, Desert, Forsake
2	Abundant	Plentiful, Ample, Copious
3	Accomplish	Achieve, Complete, Fulfill
4	Adventure	Venture, Expedition, Exploit
5	Articulate	Express, Communicate, Enunciate
6	Benefit	Advantage, Profit, Gain
7	Brave	Courageous, Fearless, Valiant
8	Bright	Luminous, Radiant, Shining
9	Calm	Serene, Composed, Tranquil
10	Create	Make, Build, Construct
11	Danger	Peril, Hazard, Risk
12	Dark	Dim, Gloomy, Shadowy
13	Difficult	Hard, Tough, Arduous
14	Eager	Keen, Enthusiastic, Ardent
15	Eliminate	Remove, Eradicate, Exterminate
16	Endurance	Stamina, Perseverance, Fortitude
17	Enough	Sufficient, Adequate, Ample
18	Excellent	Outstanding, Superb, Exceptional

19	Fast	Quick, Rapid, Speedy
20	Friendly	Kind, Amiable, Cordial
21	Generate	Produce, Create, Originate
22	Great	Grand, Magnificent, Splendid
23	Happy	Joyful, Cheerful, Delighted
24	Help	Assist, Aid, Support
25	Honest	Truthful, Sincere, Genuine
26	Idea	Thought, Concept, Notion
27	Imagine	Picture, Visualize, Envision
28	Important	Significant, Crucial, Vital
29	Intelligent	Smart, Clever, Wise
30	Joy	Happiness, Delight, Pleasure
31	Kind	Caring, Compassionate, Gentle
32	Knowledge	Wisdom, Understanding, Awareness
33	Laugh	Giggle, Chuckle, Snicker
34	Liberty	Freedom, Independence, Autonomy
35	Magnificent	Grand, Splendid, Majestic
36	Modest	Humble, Unassuming, Reserved
37	Obstacle	Barrier, Hurdle, Impediment
38	Persevere	Persist, Continue, Endure
39	Powerful	Strong, Mighty, Potent
40	Precious	Valuable, Priceless, Treasured

41	Quiet	Silent, Peaceful, Tranquil
42	Reach	Arrive, Achieve, Attain
43	Right	Correct, Accurate, Proper
44	Satisfy	Please, Content, Fulfill
45	Struggle	Strive, Fight, Endeavor
46	Successful	Victorious, Prosperous, Thriving
47	Uphold	Support, Maintain, Defend
48	Victory	Triumph, Success, Conquest
49	Wealth	Riches, Fortune, Prosperity
50	Zeal	Passion, Enthusiasm, Fervor
51	Courage	Bravery, Valor, Guts
52	Diligent	Industrious, Hardworking, Persistent
53	Empathy	Compassion, Sympathy, Understanding

4. 50+ Important Antonyms

Antonym: A word that has the opposite meaning of another word.

#	Word	Antonym
1	Above	Below
2	Abundant	Scarce
3	Accept	Refuse
4	Advantage	Disadvantage
5	Appear	Disappear
6	Begin	End
7	Big	Small
8	Brave	Cowardly
9	Bright	Dull
10	Calm	Agitated
11	Careful	Careless
12	Clean	Dirty
13	Comfort	Discomfort
14	Deep	Shallow
15	Difficult	Easy
16	Early	Late
17	Fast	Slow
18	Full	Empty

19	Hard	Soft
20	Happy	Sad
21	Honest	Dishonest
22	Hot	Cold
23	Important	Unimportant
24	Kind	Cruel
25	Know	Ignore
26	Light	Dark
27	Love	Hate
28	Mature	Immature
29	Open	Close
30	Patient	Impatient
31	Perfect	Imperfect
32	Polite	Impolite
33	Possible	Impossible
34	Rich	Poor
35	Safe	Dangerous
36	Satisfy	Dissatisfy
37	Strong	Weak
38	Success	Failure
39	Sweet	Sour
40	Tall	Short

41	True	False
42	Ugly	Beautiful
43	Usual	Unusual
44	Wide	Narrow
45	Win	Lose
46	Wrong	Right
47	Young	Old
48	Wise	Foolish
49	Generous	Miserly
50	Optimistic	Pessimistic
51	Private	Public
52	Modern	Ancient
53	Active	Inactive

5. Practice Passages

Passage 1: Literary Passage

"The old man sat by the window, watching the rain pour down. His eyes, though weary,

Questions

1. Where did the old man sit? (1 mark)
2. What did he remember? (1 mark)
3. What was the condition of his legs? (1 mark)
4. Find a word from the passage that means "tired". (1 mark)
5. Find the opposite of "broken". (1 mark)

Answers

1. The old man sat by the window.
2. He remembered walking through the fields in the warm sun.
3. His legs were weak and he could barely move.
4. Weary.
5. Unbroken.

Passage 2: Discursive Passage

"Should homework be abolished? Many argue that homework places unnecessary stress on students and takes away family time. Others believe it reinforces learning and teaches discipline. A balanced approach is essential; homework should be meaningful and reasonable. Beneficial. Moderate / Reasonable.

Questions

1. What do many people argue about homework? (1 mark)
2. What do others believe about homework? (1 mark)
3. What is the author's opinion on homework? (1 mark)
4. Find a word from the passage that means "helpful". (1 mark)
5. Find the opposite of "excessive". (1 mark)

Answers

1. Many argue that homework places unnecessary stress on students and takes away family time.
2. Others believe it reinforces learning and teaches discipline.
3. A balanced approach is essential; homework should be meaningful and reasonable.
4. Beneficial.
5. Moderate / Reasonable.

Passage 3: Factual Passage

"Technology has revolutionized the way we communicate. In the past, people relied on letters and landline phones. Modern means of communication include email, social media, and video conferencing. While technology has made communication more convenient, it has also created challenges such as digital distraction and privacy concerns. Finding a balance between technology use and personal time is essential for maintaining a healthy lifestyle.

Questions

1. What did people use in the past to communicate? (1 mark)
2. What are the modern means of communication? (1 mark)
3. What are the challenges created by technology? (1 mark)
4. Find a word from the passage that means "changed completely". (1 mark)
5. Find the opposite of "convenient". (1 mark)

Answers

1. People used letters and telegrams.
2. Smartphones, emails, and social media platforms.
3. People spend more time on devices and less time interacting face-to-face.
4. Revolutionized.
5. Inconvenient.

6. Practice Exercises

Exercise 1: Prefixes

Add prefixes to form new words:

1. happy → **unhappy**
2. write → **rewrite**
3. view → **preview**
4. understand → **misunderstand**
5. appear → **disappear**

Exercise 2: Suffixes

Add suffixes to form new words:

1. happy → **happiness**
2. educate → **education**
3. slow → **slowly**
4. comfort → **comfortable**
5. hope → **hopeless**

Exercise 3: Word Formation (HPU Style)

1. Someone who investigates is an **investigator**.
2. The property of a material to be flexible is its **flexibility**.
3. A father who doesn't care for his children is a **careless** parent.
4. To make a summary of the text: to **summarize** the text.
5. To not please the employer: to **displease** the employer.

Exercise 4: Antonyms

Word

Antonym

Dark	Light
Strong	Weak
Beautiful	Ugly
Rich	Poor
Hard	Soft

Exercise 5: Synonyms

Word	Synonym
Happy	Joyful / Cheerful
Big	Large / Huge
Fast	Quick / Rapid
Brave	Courageous / Fearless
Kind	Caring / Compassionate

Exercise 6: Inferring Meaning

1. "The weather was *inclement*, so we decided to stay indoors." — **inclement** = unpleasant (harsh / unfavorable)
2. "Her *dedication* to work earned her a promotion." — **dedication** = commitment / devotion
3. "The room was *spacious* enough to hold 50 people." — **spacious** = large / roomy
4. "His *arrogant* behavior made him unpopular." — **arrogant** = proud / haughty

7. Quick Revision

7.1 Key Points for Comprehension

- Read the passage twice
- Underline keywords
- Answer in your own words
- Use complete sentences
- Check spelling and grammar
- Time management: maximum 15 minutes

7.2 Word-Attack Skills Summary

Skill	Tips
Word Formation	Learn common prefixes and suffixes
Antonyms	Memorize common opposite pairs
Synonyms	Build vocabulary with similar words
Inferring Meaning	Use context clues from the passage

7.3 Common Prefixes

- un- (Not) → unhappy
- re- (Again) → rewrite
- pre- (Before) → preview
- mis- (Wrongly) → misunderstand
- dis- (Not / Reverse) → disappear
- in-/im-/il-/ir- (Not) → invisible, impossible, illegal, irrational
- over- (Too much) → overeat
- under- (Too little) → undercook

7.4 Common Suffixes

- -ness (State of) → happiness
- -tion / -sion (Action) → education
- -ly (In a manner) → slowly
- -able / -ible (Capable) → comfortable, flexible
- -ful (Full of) → beautiful
- -less (Without) → hopeless
- -ment (Result) → movement
- -er / -or (One who) → teacher, actor

7.5 Common Antonyms

- Above → Below
- Accept → Refuse
- Begin → End
- Bright → Dull
- Clean → Dirty
- Deep → Shallow
- Early → Late
- Full → Empty
- Happy → Sad
- Hot → Cold

7.6 Common Synonyms

- Abandon → Leave, Desert
- Brave → Courageous, Fearless
- Create → Make, Build
- Difficult → Hard, Tough
- Enough → Sufficient, Adequate
- Friendly → Kind, Amiable
- Help → Assist, Aid
- Imagine → Picture, Visualize
- Kind → Caring, Compassionate
- Magnificent → Grand, Splendid

8. Important Questions for Examination

Short Answer Questions (2 Marks)

1. What is comprehension?
2. Give two examples of prefixes with their meanings.
3. Give two examples of suffixes with their meanings.
4. What is a synonym? Give one example.
5. What is an antonym? Give one example.
6. What are word-attack skills?
7. How can you infer the meaning of an unknown word from context?

Medium Answer Questions (5 Marks)

8. Read the passage and answer the questions:

"Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world."

- a. Who said, "Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world"?
 - b. What does education provide according to the passage?
 - c. Why is education essential in today's world?
 - d. Find a word from the passage that means "allows or enables".
 - e. Find the opposite of "unimportant".
9. Explain word-formation with prefixes and suffixes. Give 5 examples of each.
10. What is the difference between a synonym and an antonym? Give 5 examples of each.

Long Answer Questions (10 Marks)

11. Read the passage carefully and answer all the questions:

"The rapid advancement of technology has transformed every aspect of our lives



- a. What has technology transformed? (1 mark)
- b. What are the benefits of technology? (1 mark)
- c. What are the negative effects of technology? (1 mark)
- d. Find a word from the passage that means "change completely". (1 mark)
- e. Find the opposite of "reduced". (1 mark)
- f. Find a synonym of "important". (1 mark)
- g. What is the author's advice regarding technology? (2 marks)
- h. Give a suitable title to the passage. (2 marks)

9. HPU BCA Exam Tips for Unit-I

Based on HPU Previous Year Papers:

1. Read the passage twice before attempting questions
2. Underline keywords in the passage
3. Answer in your own words — do not copy directly from the passage
4. Use complete sentences for full marks
5. Check your answers for accuracy and spelling
6. Manage time — do not spend too long on one passage
7. Practice word-formation — prefixes and suffixes are frequently asked
8. Learn synonyms and antonyms — 50+ each given in this unit
9. Inferring meaning from context is a frequently tested skill
10. Always write the question number before your answer

End of Unit-I Notes